

Chapter 116-1

Liang Shi's gaze swept over Liang Xinran, then over Liang Xinzhou.

Liang Xinran raised the back of her hand to wipe her tears. With reddened eyes, she said, "It wasn't until I came here that I realized I don't fit in. I can't integrate into this family, but you're different. You grew up here since you were little. The brothers all dote on you, and even Wanwan and Ling Dang like you more. I missed out on them. After I came, I did many wrong things. I'm truly sorry. I'm leaving now, but you can still be family with them. Take care of each other."

Her tone was sincere. The way she looked at Liang Shi was aggrieved and innocent. Her face was as pale as paper, with not a trace of color on her lips.

She looked weak and powerless.

Even Liang Xinran's voice was very soft when she spoke, as if a gust of wind could blow her away.

But her words made Liang Shi very uncomfortable.

Mainly because Liang Xinran's true identity was right there. Saying this to Liang Shi, the underlying meaning was—although you stole my parents and siblings, and took away the affection that should have belonged to me, I'm willing to give all of this to you. After all, I didn't grow up by their side, so none of them like me, right?

Liang Shi clearly hadn't done anything, yet now she was being made out to be the villain no matter how you looked at it.

Anyone looking at such a pale face wouldn't be able to say anything more. If it were someone soft-hearted like Liang Xinhe, they might even ask her to stay.

Liang Shi was also kind, but she knew kindness should be reserved for good people.

Being kind to everyone would make her a saint.

Liang Xinran wasn't as tall as Liang Shi, so Liang Shi had to look down at her. After a moment, Liang Shi said coldly, "Oh, then have a safe trip."

Liang Xinran: "..."

Obviously, a flash of astonishment passed through her eyes, but she quickly recovered.

Liang Shi didn't pay her any attention. Instead, she said to Liang Xinzhou, "Big Brother, you've worked hard. I'll take good care of Ling Dang."

Liang Xinzhou nodded at her. "Mm, don't tire yourself out either."

Liang Shi nodded and smiled. "I know."

The two of them had this harmonious interaction right there, completely leaving Liang Xinran hanging.

Watching the two of them, Liang Xinran was grinding her teeth in frustration, but she couldn't show any of it.

She still maintained that weak appearance. When Liang Xinzhou started walking toward the car again, Liang Xinran passed by Liang Shi's side. Just then, a gust of wind blew, and she lost her footing, falling directly toward Liang Shi.

Liang Shi instinctively wanted to reach out to support her, but she quickly came to her senses. In that split second, she pulled back her hand and quickly shifted to the side, away from her.

Liang Xinran lost her balance, her body floating unsteadily, her feet scrambling on the ground. She had already let herself fall, intending to land in Liang Shi's arms, but she hadn't expected Liang Shi to dodge. She could only try to regain her balance this way, looking like she was dancing.

It took a lot of effort before Liang Xinran finally steadied herself.

Meanwhile, Liang Shi stood with her arms crossed, looking completely uninvolved.

Liang Xinzhou had already walked to the car. Looking back and seeing Liang Xinran still standing there, he frowned and asked coldly, "Do you have anything else?"

"No," Liang Xinran said, sniffing accordingly, looking extremely aggrieved. Tears fell like water from an opened floodgate, continuously streaming down. But she stubbornly raised the back of her hand to wipe them away, like a little white flower swaying precariously in the cold wind.

Afraid she would pull another stunt, Liang Shi moved even further away from her.

Liang Xinran looked at her and smiled. "You're luckier than me. You have parents who love you, brothers who love you, and a younger sister who respects you. To be honest, I'm very envious, but I know I don't deserve to have these things. Life is a one-way track. My life was switched to a different track over twenty years ago. I have nothing to complain about. I just hope you can take good care of them in my place. Thank you."

Liang Shi: "...?"

If one didn't know better, they'd think she was performing a melodrama here.

Honestly, couldn't Liang Xinran become a hit if she became a screenwriter?

Her ability to make up lines was truly impressive.

Liang Shi listened to her words, standing there with her mind wandering.

But she didn't really take in what she was saying.

Praise on the surface, criticism underneath.

Liang Shi had heard plenty of this kind of talk before in the entertainment industry.

On the surface, they acted like good sisters, saying your journey hasn't been easy and you should be happy to have achieved so much. But the actual meaning was: you country bumpkin, who knows what kind of dumb luck you stepped in to transform from a plain chicken into a phoenix. But so what? That's as far as you'll ever go.

Liang Shi was basically immune to this kind of talk.

She hadn't done anything wrong to anyone, so she didn't care what others said.

Liang Xinran had put on a big show with no audience to appreciate it, only receiving Liang Shi's casual remark in return: "Do you not actually want to leave?"

Liang Xinran was startled, like a frightened little white rabbit. "How could that be? I'm leaving, it's just..."

She paused, then mumbled in a voice everyone could hear, "I just don't know where to go. I don't have a home anymore."

Just then, Liang Xinzhou had put down her luggage and was walking back. Hearing this, his footsteps paused slightly, his expression complicated.

Liang Shi clicked her tongue internally but said coldly, "Isn't this your home? Why don't you just stay?"

"I can't," Liang Xinran said. "The brothers and sister don't like me. I can't stay here."

Hearing this, Liang Xinzhou's expression became even more complicated.

Wasn't she directly saying—because the place I grew up in wasn't good, coming from a small mountain village, my family members all don't like me. That must be their problem, not mine.

Standing there, Liang Xinzhou suddenly spoke. "Liang Xinran, if you want people to like you, you first need to show your personal merits, not stand here playing the victim and acting pitiful. You didn't have good material conditions in Taozhi Village, but you clearly already created good enough conditions for yourself before. Although I don't know what you traded to get them, your annual salary is equivalent to that of a mid-level employee at Dongheng, even if they're top graduates from 985 or 211 universities."¹

Liang Xinzhou's words were very direct. His tall figure standing there gave off enough pressure.

"If you feel the Liang family hasn't given you enough, you can ask for more," Liang Xinzhou said. "I don't see how much you're lacking family. Your home is here, and you can come back anytime. But you shouldn't expect so much. We've all established our own families and careers. To be honest, even Liang Shi—I don't have much energy to spare for her. Yet you want everyone to revolve around you."

Liang Xinzhou adjusted his glasses. Those eyes hidden behind the lenses were sharp and piercing. The words he spoke were like a knife, precisely stabbing into Liang Xinran's weak spot.

Liang Xinzhou slowly uttered a few words: "Wishful thinking."

Footnotes:

¹ 985 and 211 universities: These refer to two prestigious university programs in China. "Project 985" includes China's top 39 research universities (like Peking University and Tsinghua University), while "Project 211" includes about 100 key universities. Graduates from these institutions are highly sought after in the job market. Liang Xinzhou is pointing out that Liang Xinran's previous income was already comparable to elite graduates, implying she wasn't as unfortunate as she claims.

Chapter 116-2

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Liang Shi felt the pressure just standing there.

Liang Xinzhou had been immersed in the business world for a long time. Even at a young age, he had dealt with those old fossils in the company, long since developing an iron-fisted approach.

Even though he was considered young in the business world, no one dared to underestimate him.

Liang Xinzhou wasn't lacking in emotional intelligence. On the contrary, he had long since mastered the ability to say the right things to the right people when making conversation at banquets.

He just couldn't be bothered to use these tactics at home.

Having to wear a mask every day at the company, he just wanted some peace and quiet when he got home. Instead, he had to face these trivial matters.

Who wouldn't be annoyed?

After Qiu Zimin fainted, Liang Xinran naturally sat by Qiu Zimin's bedside wiping her tears the whole time, looking extremely pitiful.

After the family doctor arrived and put Qiu Zimin on an IV drip, he confirmed that the fainting was caused by extreme anger affecting her heart.

He also told the Liang brothers, "This is a heart condition. If her mood is constantly depressed, this will happen. Going out for walks regularly would help."

After confirming that she was fine, Liang Xinzhou stood at the doorway observing Liang Xinran.

Liang Xinhe had indeed softened. Watching the mother he had respected his whole life get so angry she fainted again and again over such a small matter, he began to reflect on whether they, as sons, had gone too far.

Wasn't she just a biological daughter?

If they wanted to acknowledge her, then just acknowledge her.

They had already moved out anyway. Just let this person stay at home, and no one would affect anyone else.

When he discussed this with Liang Xinzhou, Liang Xinzhou shot him a sidelong glance and called him stupid.

Liang Xinhe frowned. "Then what do we do? If we really send her away, Mom will faint again when she wakes up. And what about Dad... Our family really shouldn't fall apart like this."

"With her here, it will definitely fall apart," Liang Xinzhou said. "Doesn't she want to leave anyway?"

So Liang Xinzhou called Liang Xinran out and began negotiating with her.

The negotiation was recorded.

He proposed that Liang Xinran stay in Haizhou City. He would buy her a house. The family assets would be distributed according to their parents' wishes later, but Liang Xinzhou was willing to give 1% of his own share to Liang Xinran. She would definitely not be shortchanged financially. If she wanted to come back to the old mansion to live, she could do so at any time—they wouldn't be moving back anyway.

The condition was that Liang Xinran couldn't go around flaunting her identity as the Liang family's Third Miss. Whatever work she wanted to do in the future, Liang Xinzhou would support her, but he didn't want her sitting at home doing nothing, eating away at her fortune until it was gone.

Liang Xinzhou offered very generous conditions for her to move out of the old mansion.

But Liang Xinran said she didn't want that money. She only hoped this family could be harmonious and happy, like before she came.

Liang Xinran's words were watertight, but Liang Xinzhou didn't feel the slightest guilt. He told her directly, "Whether you want these things or not won't change anything."

In the end, Liang Xinzhou didn't bother with her anymore. The conditions had been offered.

He confirmed with her multiple times whether she was truly willing to leave voluntarily. Liang Xinran hemmed and hawed for a while but still said she was willing.

So Liang Xinzhou took her luggage and left the old mansion.

He had her stay at a hotel for now, and his assistant would find her a place to live.

At this moment, facing Liang Xinran's words, Liang Xinzhou's heart was calm as still water. In the end, he still sent her away.

Liang Shi stood in place, watching that car disappear around the corner before getting into her own car.

Ling Dang was puzzled. "Where did Uncle take the new auntie?"

Liang Shi: "To a new house."

"Is the new auntie moving away?" Ling Dang asked.

Liang Shi nodded, then asked her, "If the new auntie moves away, will you move back?"

Ling Dang immediately shook her head. "I like our new home now."

To her, the new home was free and comfortable. Although it wasn't as big as the old mansion, there were fewer people at home, and she could play happily by herself. Moreover, she could be with Mommy every day when she came home. When eating, she didn't have to be as constrained as at the old mansion, where she had to wait for Grandpa to pick up his chopsticks before she could start eating.

Ling Dang didn't want to go back.

Liang Shi just smiled and patted her head. "Then tell your daddy that."

She only hoped Liang Xinhe wouldn't soften again.

Chapter 116-3

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Of course, Ling Dang naturally didn't get an apology, but the Xu Tong family apologized to Ling Dang.

Especially Xu Tong's mother—compared to before, she was like a completely different person.

That night, the Liang family naturally erupted into an argument.

When Qiu Zimin woke up and discovered that Liang Xinran had been sent away, she went crazy, cursing at the Liang brothers in the most vile language.

Father Liang sat on the sofa without saying a word, smoking nearly half a pack of cigarettes.

Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe just sat there, not refuting a single word. They had one attitude—this person must be sent away.

Qiu Zimin said, "You've all moved out now, so what does it matter to you who I keep here? You sent her away, so I'll go live with her."

Liang Xinzhou replied, "I can't control that. Do as you please, but we won't have much involvement with her."

Because of this matter, the entire Liang household was in an uproar. The atmosphere was unprecedentedly tense.

Qiu Zimin nearly fainted from anger again.

But Liang Xinzhou said, "Not sending her out of Haizhou City is already the final bottom line."

Qiu Zimin was so angry she grabbed something to hit him with, but Father Liang suddenly shouted coldly, "Enough! Do you think this family isn't chaotic enough?!"

Qiu Zimin suddenly shed two streams of tears. "What sin did I commit to deserve this..."

But Father Liang knew that Liang Xinzhou wasn't someone who would cause trouble without reason. Being this resolute this time, he must have his reasons.

He called Liang Xinzhou to the study and asked him why he did this.

Liang Xinzhou took out the information he had previously gathered and showed it to Father Liang. "Although there's no direct evidence, I don't believe this is a coincidence. Do you?"

"I had Liang Shi ask Xu Qingzhu. The reason Xu Kang was fired from Haiwei Jewelry was because he sold the concept for their summer new products to Xinlai Design for 1.2 million," Liang Xinzhou said. "And Zhang Yangning worked at Xinlai Design for a year after graduation. Zhang Yangning is also from Taozhi Village. She goes back to the village every year. Although the villagers say she and Liang Xinran don't talk to each other, I think when something is abnormal, there must be something fishy going on."^1

Liang Xinzhou was an extremely cautious person.

Father Liang looked at the information handed to him and actually found it hard to believe. No matter what, Liang Xinran had only been in Haizhou City for less than half a month. How could she have plotted so many things?

But Liang Xinzhou's words made him waver.

Moreover, he was indeed getting old. He had basically handed over all of Dongheng's affairs to Liang Xinzhou. These past few days, going back to the company to take on the responsibilities again had exhausted him.

In the end, he agreed with Liang Xinzhou's approach—better safe than sorry.

"Your mother feels too guilty toward her," Father Liang said. "She carried her for ten months and the delivery was extremely difficult. Then not long after, she was stolen. She's been thinking about it for over twenty years. It's almost become an obsession. It's not easy to let go."

"What she wants to do is her business, but we can't all lose our rationality," Liang Xinzhou said.

Father Liang looked at the stack of documents and pondered for a long time before saying, "Then let's investigate this. If we really find something, it will help your mother give up."

Liang Xinzhou acknowledged with a "yes."

The study was quiet for a long while. Then Liang Xinzhou suddenly spoke, "Dad, do you know who Liang Shi's biological parents are?"

"Liang Shi?" Father Liang paused. "Why are you asking about this?"

"Mom seemed to let something slip today," Liang Xinzhou didn't hide it. "It looks like Liang Shi wasn't picked up by Mom. It's more like she knew Liang Shi's parents, especially her mother."

Hearing this, Father Liang shook his head. "Isn't Liang Shi just an abandoned baby? When your mother and I found her, she was barely breathing, her whole body was purple and bruised, like she had been abused. We picked her up and took her to the hospital, which is the only reason she survived."

Liang Xinzhou was puzzled, but seeing that Father Liang's expression didn't look like he was lying, he gave up discussing this matter.

Footnotes:

^{^1} "When something is abnormal, there must be something fishy going on" (事出反常必有妖, shì chū fǎn cháng bì yǒu yāo): A Chinese proverb literally meaning "when things are abnormal, there must be a demon/monster behind it." It expresses the idea that when circumstances deviate significantly from the norm, there's usually a hidden cause or scheme behind it.

Chapter 116-4

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Liang Shi didn't know about the argument that erupted at the Liang family that night.

She only felt that what happened during the day was absurd. Liang Xinran had even tried to fall on her. Fortunately, she had dodged.

During dinner that evening, she told Xu Qingzhu about it.

Xu Qingzhu clicked her tongue. "That just shows how charming Miss Liang is."

Liang Shi: "..."

She picked up a piece of bamboo shoot and put it in Xu Qingzhu's bowl. "Teacher Xu, eat more."

Rainbow watched from the side, completely confused.

Because Dongheng's magazine department was recently setting up a new section, Zhou Li was swamped with work and had to work overtime late into the night, unable to look after Rainbow.

When Liang Shi took Rainbow home, it was already close to nine o'clock, but the lights at her house were still off.

Liang Shi couldn't bear to see the little one all alone like that, so she brought Rainbow back home with her.

When Zhou Li found out, she felt extremely embarrassed. But seeing that Rainbow could sit at the dining table eating a hot meal with family around her, Zhou Li couldn't bring herself to tell Rainbow to go home and stay alone. She could only shamelessly trouble Liang Shi, thanking her profusely.

Liang Shi said it was no problem.

She would be free tomorrow anyway and could watch the child for another day. Zhou Li could just treat her and Xu Qingzhu to a meal when she got paid.

Only then did Zhou Li let go of her psychological burden. She reminded Rainbow to be good at Liang Shi's house.

Rainbow was indeed very well-behaved when she was alone. She stayed there quietly without making a fuss. After dinner, Xu Qingzhu took her to the bathroom to wash up, and she could do it all by herself just by stepping on a stool.

They quickly got Rainbow settled in the guest bedroom to sleep.

By the time Liang Shi finished cleaning up the kitchen and came out, Xu Qingzhu had already finished washing up and was sitting on the sofa reading a book.

Liang Shi asked quietly, "Is Rainbow asleep?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded and couldn't help but sigh. "She's so well-behaved."

Liang Shi agreed. "Yes, Rainbow is so well-behaved she doesn't seem like a child."

After their remarks, Liang Shi quietly opened the door to the guest bedroom to check. The room was dark, and Rainbow's even breathing could already be heard. It sounded like she was fast asleep.

Only then did she close the door again. She handed Qi Jiao's diary to Xu Qingzhu before going to wash up herself.

Qi Jiao's diary was spread out before Xu Qingzhu. Actually, there was nothing particularly special about it to her.

But Qi Jiao's writing was so emotionally powerful. Combined with knowing a bit about her story, this person had become real in Xu Qingzhu's mind.

To her, she was like an angel of a sister.

If it weren't for her, she might never have met the Liang Shi she encountered later.

After finishing Qi Jiao's diary, Xu Qingzhu's mood became somewhat heavy.

When she tried to read her own book afterward, she couldn't feel anything anymore.

The words seemed to automatically transform into Qi Jiao's diary.

When Liang Shi finished washing up and returned to the bedroom, Xu Qingzhu wasn't leaning against the headboard quietly reading with her eyes lowered like usual. Instead, she sat on the bed like an old monk in meditation, her eyes unfocused, thinking about something unknown.

Liang Shi turned off the main light in the room, leaving only the two dim yellow lamps by the bed.

She lifted a corner of the blanket and got into bed, letting her loosely rolled-up sleeves fall down. Half of the bed sank slightly.

This disturbed Xu Qingzhu. She turned her head slightly to look over. Those eyes, illuminated by the faint yellow light, held a crystalline wetness and looked somewhat dazed.

"What are you thinking about?" Liang Shi asked.

Only then did Xu Qingzhu move her body, a bit stiffly. She said softly, "Qi Jiao."

Hearing this, Liang Shi pressed her lips together and asked if she had put away Qi Jiao's diary properly. Xu Qingzhu said she had put it in the nightstand drawer on her side. Then she slowly lay down, her soft fine hair falling on the pillow, and turned on her side to look at Liang Shi.

The light in the room was dim and yellow, the warm orange tones enveloping them like the glow of a sunset at dusk.

Liang Shi glanced at her and felt that her mood was severely low.

Leaning against the headboard, Liang Shi couldn't help but reach out to stroke the top of her head. She lowered her gentle voice and asked, "What's wrong?"

Xu Qingzhu's hand fell in front of her eyes, her fingers slightly curved as she touched the silky pillow. "Nothing."

That voice didn't sound like nothing at all.

Liang Shi sighed helplessly. "If I had known, I wouldn't have shown it to you."

Xu Qingzhu scoffed lightly. "I've already finished reading it."

"It's because I saw how sad you were after reading it," Liang Shi said. "That's why I didn't want to show you."

Xu Qingzhu paused briefly. After a moment, she said, "I was just thinking..."

Her cool voice suddenly stopped. In the quiet room, it was as if someone had pressed the pause button, making one's heart itch. Liang Shi's hand on top of her head also stopped.

Xu Qingzhu didn't finish what she was saying. A few seconds later, she suddenly moved closer and wrapped her arms around Liang Shi's waist.

Liang Shi's body slid down accordingly, allowing Xu Qingzhu's head to rest on her.

In that instant, she clung to her like a koala.

Her ear pressed against the spot near her heart, hearing her heartbeat with perfect clarity.

And Liang Shi's heart skipped a beat for a moment, then began to beat intensely and passionately, like rapid drumbeats.

Chapter 116-5

Liang Shi swallowed, suddenly remembering the message Xu Qingzhu had sent during the day—
—I want to passionately kiss your abs.

—Passionately kiss your abs.

—Passionately kiss.

Images were already forming in her mind.

Her face and ears instantly grew hot.

Abs were something that people who exercised regularly had, but thin people could also develop them easily.

As long as you were thin enough, your lower abdomen would be very flat. It wouldn't have muscles as firm as abs, but the feel would be similar.

Liang Shi thought of Xu Qingzhu's lower abdomen.

Xu Qingzhu had cool-toned pale skin, so under the dim yellow light, it would look especially beautiful.

Like it was coated with a layer of honey oil.

She couldn't think about this anymore.

Afraid that Xu Qingzhu clinging to her would fall off, Liang Shi held her with one arm while her other hand unconsciously rubbed her own ear.

Then Xu Qingzhu said in a muffled voice, "I was thinking, Teacher Liang, who went through all those things with Qi Jiao, must have been so sad."

A part of Liang Shi's heart suddenly caved in.

Softly caved in.

She had thought she was already indestructible when facing such matters, yet Xu Qingzhu's words made her heart turn sour again.

But Liang Shi didn't want Xu Qingzhu to notice, so she chuckled lightly. "It's fine. It's been so many years. I've already forgotten."

Xu Qingzhu tilted her head up slightly, and Liang Shi also lowered her head.

Their eyes met.

Liang Shi swallowed again. She lightly pressed her lips together—they were glistening, with a watery sheen.

They looked very soft.

Xu Qingzhu's finger suddenly landed on her lips, gently tracing along the texture of her lips, her eyes serious. "Really?"

Facing those eyes, Liang Shi suddenly couldn't lie.

She lay down along the silky sheets, her chin resting just on top of Xu Qingzhu's head, her voice muffled. "No."

Xu Qingzhu suddenly chuckled softly. While Liang Shi was still feeling sad, she planted a kiss on her chin.

It was very quick—so quick that before Liang Shi could react, she had already buried her head in Liang Shi's embrace again.

Xu Qingzhu said, "Then I'm also very sad."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi's heart ached a little. Her hand stroked Xu Qingzhu's back. "Don't be sad. It's all small stuff."

In a daze, Xu Qingzhu seemed to have returned to her childhood.

When coaxing children, Liang Shi's speaking habits would unconsciously show through, exactly the same as when Xu Qingzhu was a child.

The corners of Xu Qingzhu's mouth curved upward, but Liang Shi couldn't see it.

Xu Qingzhu said in a muffled voice, "But even small stuff hurts you."

"It doesn't hurt anymore." Afraid she wouldn't believe her, Liang Shi added, "Really!"

"But it hurts me," Xu Qingzhu still said in a muffled voice. "It hurts a lot."

Liang Shi: "..."

Hearing her say this, Liang Shi wished she could give her the whole world. As long as she wasn't hurting, anything was fine.

Liang Shi sighed softly. "Then what would make you feel better?"

Xu Qingzhu paused for a moment, then tilted her head up to look at her with glistening eyes. Her lips were very close to Liang Shi's collarbone. With each breath, all the warm air exhaled onto it, causing that patch of Liang Shi's skin to instantly flush red.

Goosebumps also rapidly spread across her skin in a fine layer.

It made her body ignite with heat.

...

Liang Shi swallowed. Her intuition told her this seemed a bit dangerous.

But as the danger approached, she also felt a hint of anticipation.

She looked at Xu Qingzhu. Those beautiful eyes of hers still held abundant tears, as if they could condense into droplets and fall at any moment.

Xu Qingzhu bit her lip, looking at her and shaking her head. "Nothing seems to work."

Hearing this, Liang Shi looked at her under the dim yellow light and, as if coaxing a child, placed a kiss on her forehead.

"Then let's sleep. You'll feel better after sleeping," Liang Shi said gently. "Don't think about those things."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Xu Qingzhu let out a soft breath. Her cool voice rang out by Liang Shi's ear, pitched low enough to sound incredibly enticing.

She said, "Then can I... dance on jiejie's collarbone... before... I... sleep?"^{^1}

Footnotes:

^{^1} "Jiejie" (姐姐): Meaning "older sister" in Chinese. It's an affectionate term that can be used between lovers, not just biological siblings. In this context, Xu Qingzhu is using it intimately/flirtatiously with Liang Shi. The phrase "dance on the collarbone" is a callback to the flirty comment Xu Qingzhu left on Liang Shi's Weibo earlier, which was "I really want to dance on wifey's collarbone"—a suggestive way of expressing desire for physical intimacy.